

Hotel ID Scanning: ID GURU, Thales & Cheaper Alternatives

Research brief for Lobby Connect — scan guest IDs and populate hotel PMS fields without APIs

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Bottom line up front

Confirmed at a live demo (June 2026): ID GURU does use a Thales scanner — but it's the discontinued AT9000 MK1. Pricing is **\$1,250 for the scanner plus a \$599 or \$699 annual subscription** (tiers vary by services). Note: ID GURU's own site claims “100% in-house OCR, no third-party” — so the in-house claim is marketing for the software layer, not the hardware. Separately, the lineage “CSSN → Gemalto → Thales” is wrong: CSSN (ScanShell/SnapShell) became Acuant, then GBG; the AT9000 came through Gemalto Cogent. Two unrelated branches.

Red flag on the hardware. The AT9000 MK1 is end-of-life — its replacement power supply is discontinued and it's superseded by the MK2. You'd be paying \$1,250 for hardware that sells for ~\$200 used (MK2) and has no clean support/replacement path. The real product you're buying is the recurring software subscription, not the scanner.

The “no-API” trick is keyboard-wedge + field-mapping. The scanner (or a small desktop agent) acts like a USB keyboard and “types” the parsed fields into whatever box has the cursor, pressing TAB between fields. ID GURU layers per-PMS “templates” on top so the right data lands in the right field.

You can match the workflow for under \$300. Driver's-license capture is easy and cheap. Passport reading is the catch — a true sub-\$300 passport reader exists but is budget Chinese-OEM hardware with no forgery/chip checks. Details and a recommended path inside.

Contents

1. How “import into the PMS without an API” actually works

This is the core of your question, so it's worth nailing down before the vendor comparisons. There are two separable layers in any “scan an ID → fill the check-in form” system, and almost all confusion comes from mixing them up.

Layer 1 — Decode. Any 2D scanner can read the PDF417 barcode on the back of a US/Canada driver's license. On its own it spits out the entire raw AAMVA string (a blob that looks like “@ANSI 636...DAQ...DCS...” into one field. That blob alone is useless for a multi-field form.

Layer 2 — Parse, map, and auto-type. Software splits that blob into named fields (first name, last name, address, DOB, license #, expiry), then re-emits the ones you want, in an order you choose, with a TAB or ENTER keystroke between each one. TAB moves the cursor to the next field on the form. That sequence — type value, press TAB, type next value — is the entire “no-API” magic. It's called a

keyboard wedge (the software/device “wedges” itself between the input device and the application, exactly as if a very fast human were typing). Because the operating system can't tell wedge keystrokes from real ones, this works in **any application that accepts keyboard input — including browser-based PMS like SynXis Property Hub and Choice Advantage.**

Why APIs aren't needed: the PMS never knows a scanner was involved. From its point of view a person typed into its normal check-in screen. No integration, no developer access, no PMS-vendor approval. That's the appeal — and also the weakness (next paragraph).

The catch — tab order. The wedge types fields in a fixed sequence and trusts that pressing TAB lands on the correct next field. If the PMS form's tab order doesn't match the scanner's output order, data lands in the wrong boxes. The vendor TokenWorks states this limitation in plain terms: their wedge fills “any web form that accepts keyboard input,” but it “would require that the cursor be located on the first field to be filled” and that the form's tab order matches. This is precisely why serious vendors (ID GURU, Guest Ban, IDScan) ship **per-PMS field-mapping templates** rather than a dumb dongle — the template is tuned to each PMS's specific screen layout.

What this means for Lobby Connect specifically: your after-hours agents operate the **hotel's** PMS (SynXis, Choice Advantage, HotelKey) — you don't own those check-in forms. So the tab-order fragility is real for you, and a tuned per-PMS solution (or careful per-PMS scanner configuration) matters more than a generic plug-and-play scanner.

2. ID GURU

What it is

ID GURU (branded **IDGuru**, one word; official site idguru.net) is a hardware-plus-software hotel ID/passport scanning product. It's one module of the **INNGuru Suite** (innguru.net), a hospitality-tech company in Roseville, California (phone +1 866-767-2771). Sibling products include SignGuru, LockGuru, and FaceGuru.

The workflow it advertises is a three-step flow: **(1) Scan & read** the license/ID/passport via OCR, **(2) Review & validate** against a “Do Not Rent” list, then **(3) Write to PMS** — “automatically fill the guest registration form in your PMS.”

Does it use Thales scanners? — Yes (confirmed at a live demo), but the discontinued MK1

Confirmed directly: at a June 2026 live event demo and follow-up sales call, ID GURU uses a **Thales AT9000 scanner — specifically the MK1 generation**. That settles the hardware question. The wrinkle is that the **MK1 is end-of-life**: its replacement power supply is discontinued and it has been superseded by the AT9000 MK2 (and the newer AT10K). Buyers of remaining MK1 units have no clean support or replacement-parts path from Thales.

This matters commercially. ID GURU charges **\$1,250 for the scanner**, but a current **MK2** sells for roughly \$200 used to ~\$1,630 new — and the MK1 you'd receive is the older, unsupported generation. In other words, the hardware is a marked-up, discontinued commodity device; the value ID GURU actually adds is the software layer (per-PMS auto-fill templates + Do-Not-Rent checks), which is what the annual subscription pays for. Their “100% in-house OCR” claim refers to that software, not the Thales hardware.

How it gets data into the PMS

ID GURU never publishes the exact technique (no public use of the words “keyboard wedge”), but the evidence points firmly to a **per-PMS desktop auto-fill / field-mapping agent, not an API**, in the base product:

- They claim it works with “any Windows-based or web-based PMS” and list 35+ named integrations, plus an explicit “works with any PMS even if it's not listed” claim.
- They publish **separate demo videos per PMS** (SynXis Property Hub, Choice Advantage, Opera Cloud, AutoClerk, Visual Matrix). A true universal wedge would need one demo, not one per system — per-PMS demos imply per-PMS field-mapping templates.
- Their Enterprise tier lists “Custom Registration Templates” as a feature and “Webhook & API Integration” as a separate **premium add-on** — confirming the base product does **not** use APIs; the API is an upsell.

Bottom line: high confidence it's a template-driven desktop auto-fill agent (your hypothesis (b)/(c)), not a simple HID wedge and not an API in the standard product.

PMS coverage

All three of your priority PMS are explicitly claimed and demoed:

- **SynXis Property Hub** (Sabre) — listed + dedicated demo video
- **Choice Advantage** — listed + dedicated demo video
- **HotelKey** — listed

Plus Opera/Opera Cloud, Cloudbeds, Visual Matrix, AutoClerk, StayNTouch, Mews, SkyTouch Hotel OS, WebRezPro, innRoad, ResNexus, and ~20 more.

Pricing (corrected from direct sales contact)

The published “starts at \$599” figure is not a one-time bundle. Per a direct sales conversation, the actual structure is:

- **\$1,250 one-time** for the scanner (Thales AT9000 MK1)
- **\$599 or \$699 per year**, a recurring subscription for the software, with the tier setting which services are included (e.g. Do-Not-Rent checks, fake-ID detection, additional integrations)

So a realistic 3-year cost of ownership is roughly **\$1,250 + (2 to 3 × \$599–\$699) ≈ \$2,450–\$3,350 per desk**, and it keeps accruing annually. The recurring subscription — not the scanner — is the real spend and the real lock-in.

3. Thales

Brand history (corrected)

The hotel-grade Thales scanner is the **AT9000 MK2**, a compact full-page passport/document reader. Its lineage is **Gemalto Cogent** → **Gemalto** → **Thales** (Thales acquired Gemalto in April 2019; it now operates as Thales DIS). Resellers brand it “Thales Gemalto AT9000 MK2.”

Important correction: the ScanShell / SnapShell scanners (often assumed to be “Thales”) are **not** Thales. Those come from CSSN (Card Scanning Solutions), which rebranded to **Acuant** in 2014 and was acquired by **GBG** in 2021 for ~\$736M. CSSN was never owned by Gemalto or Thales. So if you saw a “CSSN → Gemalto → Thales” chain anywhere, it conflates two unrelated companies.

Capabilities (AT9000 MK2)

This is genuinely high-end hardware, which is why it's expensive:

- **OCR of passport MRZ** (ICAO 9303 compliant, with checksum validation) and optional visible-zone OCR for auto form-fill
- **PDF417 / AAMVA** driver's-license barcodes, plus QR, DataMatrix, Aztec, and 1D barcodes
- **Full-page color imaging** at 400 or 720 DPI
- **Forgery authentication:** multi-wavelength illumination — near-infrared, visible white, and ultraviolet (365nm) — to validate security features
- **Optional RFID/NFC** reading of ePassport and eDL chips (BAC, SAC, EAC, PACE)

Pricing — why it's considered expensive

Source / model	Price	Notes
IDSuperShop — AT9000 MK2-RFID, new	\$1,630.75	MSRP listed at \$1,977.00
Independent industry range (full-page ID readers)	\$995 – \$2,500+	Corroborates the “expensive” reputation
eBay — AT9000 MK2 base, used/tested	~\$188	Used unit; not a reliable supply channel
CDW / ID Vision / Anixter, new	Quote-gated	Most US B2B resellers hide the price

The cost is driven by what's inside: UV/IR/visible illumination for forgery detection, a 3–10 MP imaging sensor, an ICAO MRZ OCR engine, optional RFID chip authentication, a ruggedized build, and a full SDK with support contracts. AdriaScan (a hospitality integrator) also charges an **annual software license** on top of the hardware.

How Thales gets data into a PMS

Unlike the cheap wedge approach, the AT9000's native path is its **SDK** — integrators wrap it in middleware that pushes fields into the PMS. Concretely, AdriaScan's "IDDEX" middleware uses Thales AT9000/QS2000 readers and auto-transfers ~25 parsed fields into Opera Cloud via Oracle's OHIP **API**. So ironically the premium Thales workflow often **does** use an API/SDK — the opposite of the cheap keyboard-wedge approach. Keyboard-wedge output is possible but is not the AT9000's selling point.

4. Cheaper alternatives under \$300

Split this by what you're scanning, because the economics are completely different for licenses versus passports.

4a. Driver's licenses — solved, easily, well under \$300

A cheap 2D scanner reads the PDF417 barcode; the only question is whether it **parses** the AAMVA data into named fields or just dumps the raw blob. Here's the landscape:

Scanner	Parses into fields?	Price (approx)	How / catch
TEEMI (TMSL-55/56/60, T26)	Yes	\$40–\$80	Free config; but you hand-build a hex command string — fiddly
Tera (HW0006 etc.)	Yes	\$50–\$90	On-device field selection; weaker documentation
Zebra DS2208 / DS9308	Yes (free)	\$150–\$250	Free 123Scan tool; insert TAB/ENTER between fields; clean
Honeywell Genesis 7580g / Voyager 1470g	Yes — but paid	\$150–\$300 + ~\$83 license	EasyDL 2.0 license per scanner; up to 24 fields, TAB delimiter
Symcode / Inateck (budget)	No	\$30–\$50	Raw barcode output only — not useful for forms

Correction to a common assumption: it's not true that all cheap Amazon scanners only output raw data. TEEMI and Tera **do** parse AAMVA into TAB-separated fields with no paid license — TEEMI's method is just clumsy to set up. Zebra's is the cleanest free option; Honeywell's is clean but costs an ~\$83 license per unit.

4b. Passports — the real catch

Passports have no barcode. The data lives in the MRZ (the two lines of "<<<" text at the bottom), which must be read by OCR. So a cheap driver's-license barcode scanner reads passports **not at all**. This is the single biggest trap in budget ID scanning.

A true sub-\$300, one-time, no-subscription passport MRZ reader **does** exist — it's a class of budget Chinese-OEM handheld OCR readers (RTscan IDE303, Newland-style MS430, generic units). They OCR the MRZ over USB as keyboard text and also read DL/ID barcodes. A live eBay listing of exactly this device class was found at **~\$227 + shipping (~\$267 all-in)**, in stock, no subscription.

What you give up vs. the Thales AT9000: no UV/IR forgery authentication and no RFID chip read. For simply capturing name/DOB/passport#/nationality into a form, that trade is usually fine. Honest caveats: budget MRZ OCR is ~99% accurate on clean documents but degrades under glare, tilt, or wear (~2–3 sec/scan), and specific named-unit prices are quote-driven and should be re-verified at purchase. Don't assume a DL scanner reads passports — buy and test one unit before committing.

4c. Software that maps fields into a form (no API)

Product	Cost	Fit
TokenWorks IDWedgeKB	\$945 one-time	Purest “parse DL → TAB into any form, no API” device. Not cheap.
TokenWorks IDWedgePro	\$845–\$1,095 one-time	Scanner + Windows “IDFill” app; per-app field maps; markets hotel check-in
Zebra ADF (firmware)	Scanner cost only	Cheapest no-extra-software route; configure fields + TAB in the gun itself
Honeywell EasyDL	~\$83/scanner license	Up to 24 fields, TAB delimiter; free trial corrupts output
TALtech BC-Wedge	~\$99 one-time	Generic Windows wedge software; you write the AAMVA rules
IDScan.net Parsing SDK	from ~\$175/device	A code library (effectively an API) — for building your own app

Naming note: the famous “IDWedge” keyboard-wedge product is **TokenWorks** (idscanner.com), not IDScan.net — different companies. IDScan.net sells a parsing SDK and a subscription app (VeriScan, \$33–\$150/mo), neither of which is a one-time no-API auto-filler.

4d. Will the cheap approach work with your PMS?

Yes, with the tab-order caveat from Section 1. Because keyboard-wedge typing goes into whatever field has the cursor, it works against browser-based and app-based PMS alike. Native scan support varies:

PMS	Native ID scan?	Wedge fragility for you
SynXis Property Hub	No first-party	High — browser form, no API; 3rd parties (IDGuru, Guest Ban) inject
Choice Advantage	No first-party	High — same pattern; tuned per-PMS agents are the norm
HotelKey	Yes (native)	Low/none — supports camera or external scanner directly
Opera / Opera Cloud	Yes (native)	None on the supported path
Cloudbeds	Partner (IDScan ParseLink)	Low

Real-world finding: for the two browser PMS with no native hook (SynXis Property Hub and Choice Advantage), hotels that scan IDs don't use a generic dongle — they use a desktop parsing-injection agent with a **pre-tuned per-PMS field map** (this is exactly what ID GURU,

Guest Ban, IDScan, and Innstrata sell). That confirms the cheap workflow is viable for your PMS, but the field-mapping has to be tuned per system, which is the work you're paying for.

5. Recommendation for Lobby Connect

1. **Driver's licenses: go cheap and direct.** A ~\$150 Zebra DS2208 (clean, free parsing via 123Scan) or a ~\$60 TEEMI handles US/Canada licenses well under \$300 per desk. Configure it to output the fields your hotels' PMS expects, with TAB between them.
2. **Passports: budget one test unit.** If your pilot hotel takes international guests, buy a single ~\$267 OCR/MRZ handheld and test it against the real SynXis/Choice/HotelKey forms before standardizing. Accept that it won't do forgery or chip checks — you said you don't need a registry or authentication, so that's an acceptable trade.
3. **The hard part isn't the scanner — it's the per-PMS field mapping.** Since your agents type into the hotel's PMS (not a form you control), budget effort for tuning the wedge output / template to each PMS's tab order. This is exactly the value ID GURU's \$599 bundle is selling. If you only ever support one or two PMS, doing the mapping yourself with a cheap scanner is very achievable; if you'll support many, a per-PMS-template vendor saves real time.
4. **The ID GURU math now favors building.** At \$1,250 for a discontinued MK1 scanner plus \$599–\$699/yr forever, you're mostly paying for their per-PMS auto-fill templates and Do-Not-Rent list. If you support only a handful of PMS, a current MK2 (or a cheap DL scanner + budget passport reader) plus your own field-mapping replicates the core workflow at a fraction of the recurring cost. Buy ID GURU only if their software services (DNR, fake-ID, chargeback packaging) are worth the annual fee to you — not for the hardware, which is overpriced and end-of-life.
5. **If you do consider ID GURU, push back on the MK1.** Insist on a current MK2 at minimum, or treat the discontinued hardware as a negotiating lever on price. Paying \$1,250 for an unsupported, ~\$200-secondary-market device is the weakest part of their offer.
6. **Watch data retention.** Even without a cloud registry, capturing ID data can trigger minimization/retention duties (CCPA etc.). Store only the derived fields you actually need.

Sources

IDGuru official site (product, flow, PMS list, \$599 pricing) — <https://idguru.net/>

INNGuru Suite (company, location, in-house OCR claim) — <https://innnguru.net/>

IDGuru on Apple App Store — <https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idguru-innguru-suite/id6758965722>

AT9000 MK1 power supply discontinued (EOL indicator) — <https://idscan.net/product/gemalto-at9000-mk1-power-supply-um37555-11-4005-0171-1/>

AT9000 MK2 used listing ~\$198 (secondary-market price) — <https://picclick.com/3M-AT9000-MK2-FULL-PAGE-PASSPORT-DOCUMENT-READER-135105529913.html>

Thales Gemalto AT9000 MK2 datasheet (capabilities) — https://www.adria-scan.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/03/Thales_Gemalto_AT9000-MK2.pdf

IDSUPERShop — AT9000 MK2-RFID price (\$1,630.75 / MSRP \$1,977) — <https://idsupershop.com/product/thales-at9000-mk2-rfid-license-passport-reader/>

AdriaScan IDDEX — AT9000 + Opera Cloud OHIP API middleware — <https://www.passport-scanners-hotels.com/opera-cloud-ohip/>

Card Scanning Solutions is now Acuant (CSSN rebrand) — https://www.prweb.com/releases/card_scanning_solutions_is_now_acuant/prweb12189764.htm

GBG acquires Acuant for ~\$736M (2021) — <https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/gbg-announces-it-has-agreed-to-acquire-acuant-bringing-together-two-leaders-in-the-global-digital-identity-market-with-combined-revenue-of-c265-million-301428608.html>

TokenWorks IDWedgeKB (keyboard-wedge mechanism + tab-order limitation) — <https://www.idscanner.com/product/idwedgekb-keyboard-id-scanner/>

TokenWorks IDWedgePro (hotel check-in field maps) — <https://www.idscanner.com/product/idwedgepro/>

Zebra — AAMVA parse fields / embedded DL parsing — [https://docs.zebra.com/us/en/scanners/general/ds4-series/ds4678-prg/driver-s-license-set-up/parsing-driver-s-license-data-fields-\(embedded-driver-s-license-parsing\)/aamva-parse-fields.html](https://docs.zebra.com/us/en/scanners/general/ds4-series/ds4678-prg/driver-s-license-set-up/parsing-driver-s-license-data-fields-(embedded-driver-s-license-parsing)/aamva-parse-fields.html)

Honeywell EasyDL 2.0 plug-in — <https://automation.honeywell.com/us/en/software/productivity-solutions/enabling-software/easydl-2-0-plug-in>

TEEMI driver's-license data formatting — <https://support.teemistore.com/hc/en-us/articles/32509789976852-Driver-s-License-Data-Formatting>

Generic handheld MRZ OCR reader, ~\$227 (eBay) — <https://www.ebay.com/itm/126562057262>

RTscan IDE303 handheld passport/MRZ reader — <https://store.rtscan.com/product/handheld-passport-ocr-b-mrz-reader-ide303/>

What is an MRZ (passports have no barcode) — <https://scanbot.io/blog/what-is-an-mrz/>

Guest Ban — Choice Advantage ID scanning (per-PMS injection agent) — <https://guestban.com/choice-advantage-id-scanning/>

Guest Ban — SynXis ID scanning — <https://guestban.com/synxis-id-scanning/>

TTI × HotelKey native ID scanner integration — <https://ttitel.com/hotelkey-id-scanner-integration/>

Oracle OPERA Cloud ID Document Scanning —

https://docs.oracle.com/en/industries/hospitality/opera-cloud/22.2/ocsuh/t_profiles_using_mobile_id_document_scanner.htm

Cloudbeds × IDScan.net ParseLink — <https://www.hospitalitynet.org/news/4130027/cloudbeds-and-idscannet-expand-integration-of-parselink-to-streamline-guest-check-in>

Note on confidence: ID GURU's hardware (Thales AT9000 MK1) and pricing (\$1,250 scanner + \$599/\$699 annual subscription) were confirmed via a live event demo and direct sales contact in June 2026. Vendor prices for budget scanners and accessory licenses (TEEMI, RTscan IDE303, Honeywell EasyDL) are point-in-time / quote-driven and should be re-checked at purchase. The exact PMS-write technique (wedge vs. screen-mapping template) is inferred from product structure and not separately documented.